

Illinois data center boom raises questions about potential impact on honeybees | FOX 32 Chicago

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Illinois data center boom raises questions about potential impact on honeybees ILLINOIS - As communities across the nation grapple with the rapid expansion of data centers, agricultural experts are raising concerns over the impact these massive facilities could have on our pollinators. Could data centers disrupt honeybee behavior? The backstory: Some studies suggest electromagnetic fields, or EMFs, could disrupt the behavior of bee colonies. Honeybees are natural navigators, relying on the sun and their own internal magnetic compass to travel several miles from their hive and return with pinpoint accuracy. But research suggests that exposure to man-made electromagnetic fields may cause cellular stress, reduce pollination efficiency, and disrupt their normal behavior. "Honeybees are the most studied insect on this planet. It's impressive, all of the various work they are able to accomplish — one of those things is navigation," said Naaman Gambill, chief beekeeper for The Hive: Chicago's Beekeeping Supply Store. "Early results showed that these low frequencies do have a negative effect on these bees being able to learn where to go to find forage, and that could ultimately lead to negative impacts for the hives themselves." Power lines, transformers, and other equipment inside and around data centers can generate low-frequency electromagnetic fields. With Illinois ranking among the top five states in the country for total data centers, local experts say the potential impact on honeybees is not an urgent threat — but it is something they are closely monitoring. "To have one more thing like data centers that could negatively impact our colonies is something that, of course, we are very wary about, not to mention the amount of water and carbon that these data centers do produce, which is another thing that affects our local ecosystems and thus affects our bees," Gambill said. Severe weather, like the storms that swept through the area Tuesday, can also affect honeybees. Gambill said hives kept on city rooftops are especially vulnerable to the elements, while heavy rain can wash away the nectar bees rely on for food. Dig deeper: The Hive Supply Company is a local beekeeping equipment supply store and manages more than 300 hives in the Chicagoland area. In 2023, Gambill safely relocated a swarm of honeybees that had captured the attention of onlookers at Daley Plaza. What's next: Chicago residents are permitted to maintain up to five active hives per property as long as they are registered with the Illinois Department of Agriculture. Learn more about the Illinois Bees and Apiaries Program by clicking here. The Source: The information in this article was reported by FOX Chicago's Kasey Chronis.